and said that ‘expectations from Tatas’ were high. But Air India has not yet turned out to be a dream airline.

It got caught in one storm after another, some unexpected and others offshoots of decades of mismanagement and neglect. On 26 November 2022, a drunk passenger ‘allegedly urinated on an elderly female co-passenger in the business class of an Air India New York-Delhi flight’, damaging the airline’s reputation. Its poor handing of the situation—when the woman had asked the crew for a change of seat, she was ‘offered a small seat used by the staff’; Air India failed to report the matter to the police or even inform the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA); and it only issued her ‘a partial refund of her ticket’—did not help matters either.

It took over a month, on 7 January, for CEO Wilson to express ‘regret’ and ‘pain’ over the incident. The statement from Tata Sons chairman on the next day, acknowledging that the airline’s response ‘should have been “much swifter”’, had some salutary effect. But the damage was done. The ‘fine of Rs 30 lakh on Air India’, by the DGCA further hurt its image.

In April 2023, the airlines management again ran into rough weather with the senior pilots on a host of issues, including the conditions of service and the hiring of foreign pilots.

The airline again got into a controversy when in July 2024, it ‘cancelled a Delhi-bound New York flight’ and diverted it to Barbados to ‘pick up … T20 Indian Cricket team’ when some of the passengers have alleged that ‘no substitute flight was provided.’

But Chandrasekaran is confident that he will turn around the airline. Speaking in April 2023 at a ‘Best CEOs Awards event’, he requested for ‘time to develop a world-beating product’. In September 2023, Wilson acknowledged that ‘it will take time to build a completely new Air India’ as ‘years of underinvestment’ will take a while to rectify. But he avers that by 2025, flyers will see ‘every aircraft … elevated to the highest standard’.

With Ratan as chairman emeritus and his ‘stability’ man, Chandrasekaran, as group chairman, Air India can expect to see good times as failure is not an option for either of them. Despite its many problems, its share in the domestic market grew from 26.7 per cent ‘between October and December 2023’, to 29.1 per cent in the ‘quarter between April and June in 2024’. On the international routes for the corresponding period, Air India’s market share grew from 23.56 per cent to 24.79 per cent.